04 – Data privacy in everyday use

Definition: Data privacy in everyday AI use means: you consciously decide which information you enter into a chat, because inputs are stored and, depending on the service or setting, can also be used for training.

> **Remember:** Would I write this on a postcard? If not, it doesn't belong in the chat.

Key points

- **Free plans:** Inputs can be stored and, depending on provider or settings, used for training. Check this with your service.
- **Never enter:** passwords, API keys (digital keys to services, more in topic 14), PINs, ID and bank details, other people's health data, confidential company data, customer data.
- **Anonymize:** Replace names, places, companies and numbers with placeholders like "Person A" or "Company X". Give only as much information as necessary.
- **Check settings:** Turn off training use (if offered), delete histories, use temporary chats. The available options differ from service to service.
- **Work:** Follow your employer's rules. Use a company account instead of your personal account if one is available. If you are unsure, ask first.
- **Files and screenshots** often contain more than you think: metadata (hidden extra details like author or location where the photo was taken), background, other tabs, names in headers.
- **Sent is sent:** Once you have entered something, you can barely control it anymore.

Example (before/after)

Before (not good):

```
Write a payment reminder to Mr. John Doe, Sample Street 5,
00000 Sampletown. He owes us money for invoice 2026-0815.
```

After (anonymized):

```
Write a friendly but firm payment reminder to Person A.
It concerns an open invoice in the amount of X. The deadline is date
↪ Y.
```

You then add the real details yourself to the finished text, outside the chat.

Do / Don't

Do	Don't
Use placeholders instead of real names	Type in real names, addresses, numbers
Check your privacy settings	Assume everything stays private
Crop or redact screenshots	Upload entire screens
Ask first when work data is involved	Process company data on a personal account

Safety note

This is general guidance, not legal advice. If in doubt, ask a specialist or your data protection officer (more in topic 22). Other people's data in particular needs special protection.

Mini checklist

- ☐ I know the postcard rule.
- ☐ I know what never belongs in a chat.
- ☐ I have checked my privacy settings.
- ☐ I anonymize texts before entering them.
- ☐ I know my employer's rules.

Exercise (5 min.)

Take a short text of your own, e.g. an email. Replace all names, places, companies and numbers with placeholders before entering it into the chat. Then ask the AI to improve the text. Check: Is the result still usable? What do you miss?

Next

- Extra exercises: `02_extra_exercises/04_extra_exercises`
- Test: Test A (Foundation)
- Related: 03 Model selection, 07 Prior knowledge & context, 12 Prompt injection, 22 Legal & compliance

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